reading the reports that had been filed through the day by Brigade HQ when the GOC had initially ordered him to move another company of 1/9 GR to Bridge 5. The question is, had he himself read and understood them or was he championing the withdrawal so fervently that he lost sight of everything else? If the Chinese attack was imminent, as he himself repeatedly said, then 7 Brigade should have had gone over the various likely scenarios. Ever since Kaul had departed from the vicinity of Bridge 4 on 10 October, Dalvi, despite having been handed back his command, seems to have frozen, hanging on to the hope that any day the order would come to extricate the brigade from the Nam Ka Chu Valley.

Be that as it may, by 18 October when the Chinese openly began ranging targets and marking the ground, their intent was clear. The brigade major, Rex Kharbanda, asked to meet the Intelligence officers of the three battalions deployed on the riverfront. He said to them, ‘You guys are talking about so much Chinese movement opposite you. Let us take stock.’ Yet, as the day progressed, nothing was done. The Grenadiers and the Punjab positions at Bridge 1 and Bridge 2 were relatively safe from a frontal attack owing to the steep cliffs on the northern side. Even if he could not take the decision to pull back from the Nam Ka Chu, Dalvi should have reinforced the thinly spread out Rajput positions with some of 9 Punjab’s platoons. Surely, given the large gap west of Temporary Bridge, he had to be aware of danger to the flank. The Grenadiers, hopelessly cramped amidst rocks, could have occupied the Punjab positions on Bridge 2. In the prevailing tense atmosphere in Brigade HQ, none of this was done or even contemplated. Even an exit plan to extricate the brigade in the event of an attack was not worked out.

Positioned above Dhola (Che Dong) was 1/9 GR, their defences straddling the track that led from the Assam Rifles post to Brigade HQ and then onto Tsangdhar. The central position was held by a platoon from Delta Company that had its remaining two platoons stationed at Tsangdhar. Charlie Company was slightly further up, to the east of the track, while the right side was held by two platoons of Alpha Company. The third platoon of Alpha Company had been dispatched on 18 October to Bridge 5 to support the Punjabis. Bravo Company was deployed around Brigade HQ.

The 34 Heavy Mortar Battery under the command of Major Balraj Nijjar had been deployed one and a half kilometres north of Tsangdhar. Dalvi had told Nijjar that since they were in a defensive posture, the